



"EVERYONE HAS AN EMOTIONAL RELATIONSHIP WITH THE MOON," SAYS WASHINGTON

deliberately been left unfinished. The idea is for the dark side of the moon to merge with the night sky, creating an illusion of fullness. In a time when the social and political milieus of the country all seem divided, 'Chand' is also a very secular moon; for it is at once, depending on the angle, the full moon of Puranmashi and the crescent moon of Eid.

Making moons, one sees, comes to Washington naturally. The NID-trained product designer—also an actor and creator of contemporary interiors—is, for instance, known for her wall-mounted drop chairs. Of these, the moon drop chair, which has a painting of the moon's surface on its stretch fabric, remains popular.

Washington had specially made the first of her moon installations—three helium-filled balloons, selectively lit to show stages of the moon—for the opening night of the Kochi Biennale in 2014. In 2016, she took the moons to the Burning Man Festival in Nevada, US. Here, she hoisted four moons over the shell of a jumbo jet. The moons, lit by the LED panels stitched into them, moved with the breeze to create the impression of the moon's various stages, happening as if in a time lapse. This year, the Burning Man organisers have invited their "moongirl" to create another installation. "I want to use flames over an installation which will be of the height of a double-storeyed building," she says.

Geeta Mehra, director, Sakshi Art Gallery, who hosted her first show, describes her work as "whimsical and aesthetic...with design crossing over into art and vice versa". But why this fascination with the moon? "Because everyone has a visceral emotional relationship with it," says Washington.

"I wanted to bring a little surprise and magic to the people." Watching a young girl stare at 'Chand' with her mouth wide open, it seems only obvious the artist has succeeded. ■

–Bandeep Singh



Amar Nath Sehgal's sculptures expressed a deep concern for social and humanitarian issues

says, "He was a loner who didn't fraternise with the Indian community of artists. I think he enjoyed a friendship with himself."

Initially employed as an engineer, Amar Nath Sehgal later embraced art and trained under the great B.C. Sanyal. But it was his travels to the West that gave him the necessary exposure to produce a kind of minimalist sculpture that would later become his signature. Working mainly in bronze throughout his six-decade-long career, Sehgal's works showed a deep concern for social and humanitarian issues. Every artist, he believed, "has to be a humanist first". His Partition output attests to that sentiment. Much like Edvard Munch's 'The Scream', 'Anguished Cries' (1959) poignantly evokes the suffering and violence of 1947.

Sehgal settled down in Delhi on a plot of land in Jangpura that Nehru provided for him in 1964. Nehru's patronage in the early years helped the artist financially. Of the multiple commissions that Nehru offered him, one was to design a sprawling mural for the Vigyan Bhawan. It was torn down in 1979 without consulting him, prompting him to take the government of India to court. After a 13-year battle, the Delhi High Court finally ruled in his favour in what went on to become a landmark judgment related to copyright law. "He was given a paltry compensation for all that he went through, but it was never about money for him," says his son Rajan. ■

–Shaikh Ayaz